But, as in any great pursuit, there are challenges and obstacles in cricket. Herschelle was not immune to this. As he started playing against better opposition, they worked out his shortcomings and would specifically target those aspects of his game – both mental and technical. He quickly realised he would have to adapt and work out new strategies that would give him the consistency to be a long-term fixture in the South African team. He did this and he did it well.

I'm not sure when it was or how it came about, but a decision was taken that Herschelle should open the batting in all forms of the game. This was the beginning of a long and enjoyable partnership, as he and I opened the batting for South Africa and Western Province. I look back on this period as one of the most memorable in my cricket career.

Herschelle and I complemented each other perfectly. He allowed me to play my natural game without the pressure of having to score runs freely. I encouraged him to play more of a percentage game when it was required. It was during these years as an opener that he tightened up his technique and became a difficult batsman to get out. Herschelle was able to combine his natural flair and skill with good control and organisation at the crease. Thus grew one of the best and most feared batsmen in the world.

Many people will be unfamiliar with Herschelle the person. The media have projected him as something of a maverick, prone to self-destruction and always living on the edge. On some levels, this is an accurate reflection, and Herschelle would be the first to tell you that. He has always done things to the extreme, so whether it is training in the gym, batting in the nets or going out for a party, he is going to give 100 per cent commitment to it!

What has not been as well documented is what a thoroughly genuine and generous human being he is. He would be more than happy to give the shirt off his back, if that meant making someone else's day. He has set a fantastic example to future sports stars in his willingness to give to others, and many people have benefited from his enormously generous heart. He has always been fully aware of the privileges that cricket has given him in his life and has never taken that for granted.

Herschelle has made many friends in the cricket fraternity. He is well liked because he has a tremendous ability to connect with people quickly. On many occasions I have seen him with a smile on his face, happily signing autographs and engaging with cricket fans and young aspiring